



# Within Deals?

## circumspection as a potboiler-worthy probe high-end car racket

### GUILTY AS CHARGED

That description could legitimately apply to Dulquer and Mammootty, considered to be among the biggest motorheads in Mollywood with an impressive fleet of luxury cars in their garages. Dulquer's collection includes a Mercedes-Maybach GLS 600, a Mercedes-AMG G63, a Range Rover Defender, a Porsche Panamera, the BMW 7 Series, Porsche 911 GT3, Mercedes-Benz SLS AMG and a Ferrari 458 Spider. He also has an impressive collection of high-end bikes—his road movies presumably entailing a touch of method acting.

Problem is, none of this is in any way illegitimate ipso facto—as Dulquer has been at pains to point out. All his purchases have been above board, he insists, paid for through legit bank channels and with proper documents—

**Takeaways**

- **A customs probe imputes links between top Kerala stars and luxury car smuggling**
- **Prithviraj Sukumaran of *Empuraan*, Dulquer Salmaan, his superstar dad Mammootty face raids; critics cry vendetta**

officials, he said, acted with "preconceived bias" in refusing to verify these.

Casual rumour-mongering flowing from the case, linking his name to "gold smuggling, narcotics and even anti-national activities", had further hurt him, he said. He stated as much in a petition to the Kerala High Court, seeking the release of a seized 2004 Land Rover Defender which he said had originally been shipped by the Red Cross. He found validation as the court accepted his plea and ordered the vehicle to be released.

### THE SUB-PLOT THICKENS

In the media, the idea of a stunning investigation with strands reaching from celebrity villas to shady hawala trails still ruled, depending on which outlet you read. If all the juicy tidbits linking Mollywood stars to car smuggling found enough credulous takers, the sceptics saw too many moving parts, in dubious concert. That the targeted megastars and actors are not necessarily aligned to the present political setup is an obvious red flag. Whispers of vendetta didn't take too long coming.

Prithviraj, an outspoken star-turned-producer/director, was last in national news for his film *Empuraan*, which stirred a hornet's nest with its uncommonly bold and candid takes on the Gujarat riots of 2002. Dulquer is for the most part soberly apolitical in public, like his father, but had plumped for secularism and democracy during the anti-CAA protests. As for Mammootty, he may not have been the only one to mark the irony: Mohanlal, his friend and fellow superstar, was receiving the Dadasaheb Phalke award while he was getting visitations from raiding parties.

A senior advocate in the high court outlines that defence. "This case is a classic example of trapping celebrities and putting pressure on their lives. The message is clear: either you yield to us politically or we will use all agencies to hunt you," he told INDIA TODAY. In the prevailing climate, one's name can be incrimination enough, of course. ■